

Operationalizing Administrative Reparations for Conflict-Related Sexual Violence in Nigeria

An Empirical Call to Action for Ministry Partners, the National Human Rights Commission, and Civil Society Coalitions

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Focus: Subnational Transitional Justice & Reparations | **Empirical Data:** SVAC Dataset (PRIO/Harvard, 1995–2023)
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1. Context & The Need for Administrative De-linking

Over nearly three decades of armed conflict across Northeast and North Central Nigeria, Conflict-Related Sexual Violence (CRSV) has caused deep trauma, long-term physical injuries, and severe poverty. While security stabilization remains a national priority, survivor support cannot be reached through our current justice system.

The plain reality on the ground is that there is simply no system or framework in place for victim compensation—whether an attacker is convicted in court or not. Those who directly carried out the violence are individual fighters who are largely unidentified, deceased, or hiding in remote bush enclaves, making it impossible for survivors to seek damages from them. At the same time, counter-terrorism judicial proceedings and military dockets focus strictly on state security offenses, offering zero restitution, financial remedy, or standing to victims. Because of this, thousands of survivors receive zero urgent healthcare, specialized surgery for internal injuries, or trauma counseling.

As sovereign duty bearers, the government has an official responsibility to step in and protect its citizens. Administrative reparations must be established outside the court system to provide immediate, dignified, and trauma-informed victim compensation that delivers real help without waiting for trials that will never come.

2. Empirical Baseline: Documented Violations & Institutional Exposure (SVAC Data)

Actor Entity	Analytical Category	Violation Years	Peak Severity (0–3)	Child Prevalence (0–3)	Documented Active Horizon
Boko Haram (JAS)	Non-State Armed Group	13	Level 3 (Systematic)	Level 3 (Systematic)	2010–2023
ISWAP	Non-State Armed Group	6	Level 2 (Massive)	Level 2 (Massive)	2018–2023
State Armed Forces / Police	Statutory Sovereign Forces	14	Level 3 (Systematic)	Level 2 (Massive)	2004–2019
Cumulative Aggregate Profile	Cross-Conflict Horizon	33	Level 3	Level 3	1995–2023

3. Actionable Policy Pillars for Operationalization

- **Pillar A: Establish an Administrative Reparations Board:** The Federal Government and state authorities in Borno, Yobe, and Adamawa should set up an independent, non-judicial Reparations Board. Operating separately from courtroom trials, this body would verify claims through simple, confidential administrative procedures—providing immediate medical vouchers, mental health care, and direct stabilization stipends.
- **Pillar B: Implement a Safe, Survivor-Led Registration System:** To overcome fear, stigma, and mistrust, the intake system must be designed and run hand-in-hand with trusted local survivor networks and civil society organizations. Strict privacy, data protection, and confidentiality standards must be maintained to keep survivors safe from exposure or retaliation.
- **Pillar C: Support Children Born of War:** With 19 actor-years showing massive and systematic violations against children, children born of wartime rape face deep social rejection and lack legal documentation. The Ministry of Interior and the National Identity Management Commission (NIMC) should provide barrier-free birth certificates and guaranteed access to free schooling, protecting these children from lifelong vulnerability.
- **Pillar D: Ensure Guarantees That Harm Will Not Recur:** Because statutory security forces account for 14 documented violation years (42.4% of total recorded exposure), reparations must go hand-in-hand with clear security sector reforms. This means embedding strict, enforceable rules against sexual violence into military codes of conduct and maintaining independent human rights oversight units to ensure these abuses never happen again.

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